



Such a Long Journey

DELHI No one is holding their breath over the Liberhan Commission's report. Constituted on December 16, 1992 to probe the sequence of events leading to the demolition of the Babri Masjid in Ayodhya, the commission is on its 47th extension, which will expire on March 31, 2009.

It was constituted by the then prime minister P.V. Narasimha Rao 10 days after the demolition of the Ram Janmabhoomi-Babri Masjid. The commission was to complete its job—probing the roles played by the then chief minister, ministers, state administration officials and others, which led to the

TIME LAG: The Babri Masjid demolition inquiry

demolition and the subsequent riots—within three months of the incident. Those who have appeared before the commission include the late Rao, then chief minister Kalyan Singh, BJP leaders L.K. Advani and Murli Manohar Joshi, Uma Bharati and Samajwadi Party chief Mulayam Singh Yadav.

The commission is headed by Justice (retd) M.S. Liberhan, who is based in Chandigarh. Its secretariat is at Vigyan Bhavan in Delhi. It has made 400 sittings and heard over 100 witnesses. But the question is, what will be the importance of its report 16 years from the day it was constituted, if it is completed and submitted at all.

by Shyam Lal Yadav

A Second Saint

THIRUVANANTHAPURAM

October 12 will be a golden day in the 2,000-year history of India's Christian community. Sister Alphonsa Muttathupadath (1910-1946) of Kerala will become the first Indian woman—and second Indian—to be canonised and declared a saint by Pope Benedict XVI at the Vatican. Sister Alphonsa, who belonged to a poor family in Kottayam district, was beatified by Pope John Paul II in 1986



Stepping Up the Heat

BHOPAL The backlash has begun. Following the thrashing of two-time BJP MP from Sagar Virendra Kumar Khtik by the Railway Police, Madhya Pradesh DGP S.K. Raut has ordered an inquiry into the incident. The inquiry officer, Railway IG Aruna Mohan Rao, has been asked to submit his report in three days. Attempt to murder cases have been registered against six General Railway Police (GRP) and Railway Protection Force (RPF) personnel, including RPF Commandant Sarika Rao. Khtik received serious



GIVING IT BACK: BJP MP Khtik who was thrashed

injuries to his head, back and hand in a cane charge by the GRP and RPF in Bina on October 3. He had to be rushed to Bhopal's Hamidia Hospital in a serious condition. The beating occurred when Khtik was leading an agitation of local traders against the

GRP and RPF's drive to remove encroachments from railway land. The state BJP is now demanding the resignation of Railway Minister Lalu Prasad Yadav for allegedly shielding the policemen who lathi-charged the MP.

by Ambresh Mishra

BLESSED: Sister Alphonsa

during his visit to Kerala. The nun belonged to the Congregation of the Poor Clares of the Third Order of St Francis.

In March this year, the Pope decided to elevate her to sainthood after a decades-long procedure which included the Vatican's confirmation of the miracles ascribed to her. Over 3,000 delegates from Kerala's Syro-Malabar church—India's largest Catholic denomination tracing its origins to St. Thomas—will attend the canonisation. The only Indian canonised before was Saint Gonzalo Garcia, a Jesuit priest born in Vasai near Mumbai to an Indian mother and Portuguese father in 1556. by M.G. Radhakrishnan